

MODULE 21 / 40

House Finch

Haemorrhous mexicanus

QUICK STATS

Length	5.1 – 5.5 in (13 – 14 cm)
Wingspan	7.9 – 9.8 in (20 – 25 cm)
Weight	0.6 – 0.9 oz (16 – 27 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The House Finch is one of the most familiar and abundant feeder birds in North America — a cheerful, sociable finch whose rosy-red male is a year-round fixture at sunflower feeders from coast to coast. Native to the western United States and Mexico, the House Finch was illegally sold as a cage bird (marketed as "Hollywood Finches") in New York in the 1940s. When dealers faced prosecution under the Migratory Bird Act, they released their birds on Long Island — and from that small population, the species colonized the entire eastern United States within 50 years, one of the most remarkable range expansions in North American ornithological history. Today it is among the top five most abundant feeder birds nationally.

HABITAT & RANGE

The House Finch is now found year-round across virtually the entire contiguous United States, southern Canada, and Mexico. It thrives in human-modified landscapes: suburban gardens, parks, farmland, orchards, and city centers. It is rarely found in dense forest or wilderness, strongly preferring areas with buildings, feeders, and ornamental plantings. It is a permanent resident throughout its range and does not migrate, though local movements occur in response to food availability.

DIET & FEEDING

- Black-oil sunflower seeds — the top feeder choice
- Nyjer (thistle) seed — eagerly taken from tube feeders
- Safflower seeds and sunflower chips
- Wild weed seeds: dandelion, thistle, mustard, knotweed
- Wild berries and small fruits — especially in autumn
- Flower buds and petals in spring

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

House Finches are highly gregarious, forming flocks of up to several hundred birds outside the breeding season. They are boisterous and active at feeders, often arriving in chattering waves and dominating smaller birds. The intensity of the male's red coloration is entirely diet-dependent — birds with access to carotenoid-rich foods such as berries and fruits develop deeper, more saturated reds, while those on poor diets may be pale orange or even yellowish. Females use this color intensity as a reliable indicator of male quality when choosing a mate. House Finches are highly adaptable and frequently nest on buildings, in hanging baskets, and in wreaths.

NESTING & BREEDING

House Finches are prolific and flexible nesters. They build compact cup nests of grasses, leaves, and rootlets in a wide variety of sites — tree cavities, dense shrubs, building ledges, hanging planters, and even old nests of other species. The female incubates 2–6 pale blue eggs with fine dark spots for 13–14 days. The male feeds the female during incubation. Both parents feed the nestlings regurgitated seeds, which fledge at 12–19 days. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season, sometimes beginning in February in southern areas.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The House Finch's song is a bright, rambling warble of musical phrases — cheerful, variable, and delivered with great energy from a prominent perch. Males sing year-round, including on cold winter days. The call is a sharp "wheet" or rising "wiit." House Finches are one of the most frequent singers at winter feeders, often heard before they are seen.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining slightly
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The House Finch population is estimated at 267 million individuals but has declined noticeably since the mid-1990s, largely due to an epidemic of Mycoplasmal conjunctivitis — a bacterial eye disease that spread rapidly through feeder populations beginning in 1994. Keeping feeders scrupulously clean is the single most important action feeder owners can take to protect House Finch populations.

FEEDER TIPS

- Black-oil sunflower seeds in a tube feeder are the top attraction
- Clean feeders thoroughly every 1–2 weeks — House Finches are prone to eye disease
- Remove and discard any birds seen with swollen, crusty eyes immediately
- Nyjer feeders bring in mixed flocks of House Finches and goldfinches
- House Finches nest on buildings — a hanging planter may become a nest site

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head & breast (male)	<i>Rosy red — intensity varies by diet</i>
Rump (male)	<i>Bright red — key field mark</i>
Back & wings	<i>Brown, streaked dark</i>
Belly	<i>White with brown streaking</i>
Female — overall	<i>Brown, heavily streaked — no red</i>
Bill	<i>Short, curved, conical, pale</i>

COLOR ME!

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